Giving advice and warning

Goal: To give advice and warnings to consumers in a polite or firm way, choosing the right modal or structure for each situation.

The idea in two lines: Advice suggests what is good to do; a warning tells someone about a danger and its consequence. Both often appear in consumer-safety texts, leaflets and advertisements.

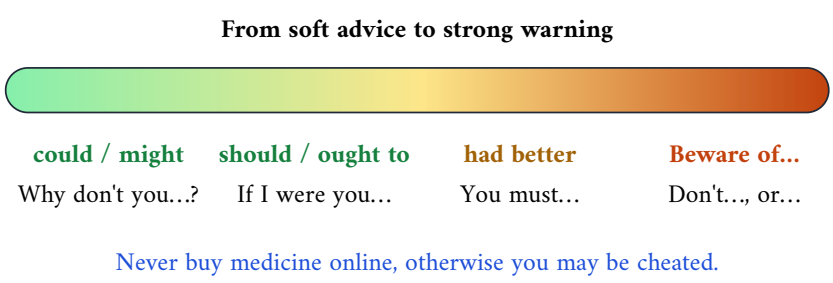


Figure 1: A scale of expressions, from gentle suggestion to firm warning.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Advice with modals:** should / ought to + base verb; negative *shouldn't*.
2. **Had better** ('d better + base verb): strong advice with a hidden danger; negative *had better not*.
3. **Other advice forms:** *If I were you, I would…*; *Why don't you…?*; *I advise you to…*; *It's a good idea to…*
4. **Warning with the imperative:** *Be careful! Watch out! Never… / Don't…*
5. **Warning + consequence:** *imperative + or / otherwise / or else + result.*
6. **Unless / if** can also warn: *Unless you check the label, you may buy fake goods.*

🟢 Examples

1. Give advice: *A friend always buys products because of ads.* **Solution:** You **should** compare prices and read reviews before buying.

2. Rewrite as a warning: *If you don't read the expiry date, you may get ill.*
   Solution: Read the expiry date, **otherwise** you may get ill.
3. Choose: *You (had better / had better to) keep chemicals away from children.*
   Solution: had better. **Explanation:** *had better* takes the base verb without *to*.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing *should to* or *had better to*; both take the base verb.
- Using *If I was you* in formal writing instead of *If I were you*.
- Writing *hadn't better*; the negative is *had better not*.
- Forgetting the consequence after *or / otherwise*.

🟡 Quick review

- Advice: should, ought to, If I were you, Why don't you…?
- Strong advice: had better (not) + verb.
- Warning: Be careful / Never / Don't…
- Warning + result: …, or / otherwise + consequence.

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